

Hundreds claim to have seen UFO

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In Yorktown, people don't usually call the police when visitors arrive from out of town. As long as they aren't from outer space.

Thursday night, Yorktown police and neighboring departments were flooded with calls from people who said they had

seen strange lights in the sky, an Unidentified Flying Object.

The descriptions of the object matched those given exactly a week earlier by people in Putnam County who had reported seeing lights over Interstate 84. The lights, callers said, were arranged in a V-shape, and appeared to be placed along the edges of a large, triangular flying craft.

More than 100 calls were received

Thursday night, mostly by police in Yorktown, but also in New Castle, Mount Kisco, Carmel and Putnam Valley.

Yorktown Patrolman Kevin Soravilla saw the lights twice within a 45-minute period Thursday night.

"The first was when I was on Route 118," Soravilla said. "The craft was traveling south. At first I thought it was a large transport aircraft. It had six or eight lights on it, and the thing was huge.

"Then it looked like it stopped, and it turned and looked like it went perpendicular to the ground. I then saw red, blue and green lights on it. Then it swerved and went in the other direction. At first I thought it was a dirigible because it seemed to be floating, but a dirigible couldn't have moved like that."

Soravilla's description of the phenomenon — "An equilateral triangle with one side missing, a V," — was almost identical to that given by other people who observed the sight, first reported at 8:45 p.m.

Soravilla saw the lights again 45 minutes later as he stood outside police headquarters with dispatcher James Wolf.

Some people thought the lights resembled slow-moving, propeller-driven aircraft flying in formation, but according to the Federal Aviation Administration, there were no aircraft in the area at that time.

Radar stations operated by the FAA on Long Island did not record any planes or helicopters flying within 100 miles of Yorktown. Airports in Westchester, Dutchess County and Connecticut were handling no air traffic at the time, and the Air National Guard — which usually gets blamed for this sort of commotion — said no Guard aircraft was in the air then.

"At first we thought it might be a flight of choppers, because the Air National Guard is moving to Stewart Airport later this year," said FAA spokesman Robert Fulton. "But they had nothing flying whatsoever."

Opinion was mixed about what it was that floated slowly over Yorktown, but whatever it was nearly caused accidents when motorists stopped in the streets to gawk.

"We don't know for sure what it was," said Yorktown Police Sgt. Anthony Masi, who added, "This is not a case of kooks calling — police officers saw it, too."

To one eyewitness, Bonnie O'Brien of the Croton Heights section of Yorktown, the lights initially looked like one object, but then became differentiated.

"My son yelled to come outside," Mrs. O'Brien said. "He thought at first that it was a UFO."

Sgt. Vincent Puma of Carmel police, where police officers in patrol cars once followed a slow-moving, luminous object as it moved across the town's airspace, said police received reports Thursday "of this huge thing in the sky. People

just went wild over it."

And one week ago, almost to the minute, residents of Kent called police to report a similar phenomenon over I-84. The calls came in at about 8:40 p.m. March 17.

Again, airport officials said no planes were in the air at that time.

One man who definitely didn't think the lights last week were from planes was a truck driver heading down Interstate 684 in Brewster.

Sgt. Joseph Andrew of the Air National Guard security detachment at Westchester County Airport said the truck driver came into the security office that night and reported a UFO sighting.

"He was really shook," Andrew said. "He said he was driving along when he saw these lights, 10 or 15 feet off the ground, right in front of him. He said when he stopped near it, he got static on his radio. Then, all of a sudden, zoom — it disappeared."

The truck driver told Andrew that, "It looked as big as one of the hangars we have here," and that lights were ranged along the edges of the craft.

A Brewster resident who lives near I-84 corroborated the truck driver's account.

The man, who asked that his name not be used because he is a Putnam County official, said he got a close-up view of the craft at about 8:40 p.m.

One neighbor, Linda Nicoletti of Tonetta Lake Road, said she was sitting in her living room when she saw the lights.

"I told my husband it looks like an airplane, but it's so low," Mrs. Nicoletti said. "I didn't hear any noise until it went over the house, and then I heard a muffled engine noise."

Andrew, who said Air National Guard aircraft would not be mistaken for this week's or last week's phenomena — "the lights on our O-2's are different" — said he envied the people who had reported the sightings.

"I want to see one of those myself," he said.